The Oval Review

A monthly examination of markets, macro, and the forces beneath them

THE OVAL FINANCIAL FORUM · OHIO STATE UNIVERSITY

OUR MISSION

The Oval Financial Forum was founded with the understanding that one of the best ways to retain information is by writing about it. Through the publication process, members have the opportunity to develop skills that the classroom cannot replicate. We hope you enjoy this edition!

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THE MONTH IN BRIEF

Market Overview

September 2026 was a divergent month, as contrasting outcomes appeared across a variety of markets. Heightened Treasury yields and oil prices renewed uncertainty surrounding inflation, contributing heavily to the underperforming indices. The S&P 500 (SPX) and Dow Jones Industrial Average (DJI) fell short in September, falling 0.45% and 4.29%, respectively. The Nasdaq composite outperformed the other major indices, gaining 1.86% in September. Technology stocks outperformed in September, limiting the overall damage to the S&P and allowing Nasdaq to post a monthly gain.



THE STATUE OF ABRAHAM LINCOLN AT THE LINCOLN MEMORIAL, WASHINGTON, D.C.
PHOTO: GEORGE W. BRADBURY

AI greatly contributed to the success of the technology landscape. Semiconductors helped to propel the sector, as Intel (INTC) gained 34.32% and Advanced Micro Devices (AMD) rose 29.96%. The strength wasn't limited to chipmakers alone, as Meta (META) jumped 26.7% over the same period, demonstrating how investors are rewarding companies across the AI supply chain. On September 28, Nvidia (NVDA) increased its share buybacks by $150 billion, bringing the total buyback authorization to $235 billion. This marked the largest share repurchase authorization increase in history and exemplified confidence within the technology sector.

Despite a strong performance from the technology sector, markets were still very volatile, with elevated Treasury yields contributing to increased volatility in markets throughout the month. The raise in yields occurred late in the month, as the 10-year yield reached 5.27% on September 28, before reaching 5.31% on the final day of the month. The 30-year yield reached 5.65% on September 30, marking the highest rate since 2002.

Ongoing conflict between the United States and Iran has led to recent increases in oil prices. Disruption surrounding the Strait of Hormuz has led to disturbances regarding energy exports. On September 9, conflict across the Persian Gulf caused Brent crude to surpass $101 per barrel. Prices only went up from there, as Brent crude reached a monthly high of $110.19 per barrel on September 11. Brent crude remained near or above $100 per barrel for the remainder of September and closed the month at $103.53.

September was a notable month for cryptocurrencies, as Bitcoin (BTC-USD) climbed 6.37%. From September 21 to September 25, US spot Bitcoin ETFs gained approximately $2.4 billion. Bitcoin was heavily outperformed by other major cryptocurrencies, with NEAR (NEAR-USD) gaining 178.49% and Arbitrum (ARB-USD) increasing by 85.48%. Precious metals declined in September, as Gold fell by 6.58% and Silver posted a 9.24% retreat.

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	MTD	YTD
S&P 500	7,651.54	-0.45%	+11.77%
NASDAQ Composite	26,861.06	+1.86%	+15.57%
Dow Jones	50,906.05	-4.29%	+5.9%
10-Yr Treasury	5.29%	+53 bps	+113 bps
WTI Crude	$90.42	+5.43%	+57.47%
Gold	$4,186.70	-6.58%	-3.56%

Timeline of the Month

SEPT 9	Brent crude closed at $101.21/barrel, its highest close since May 22, as Middle East conflict intensified.
SEPT 15	Bitcoin fell to $75,600, its lowest closing price of the month, after the CLARITY Act failed to advance in the Senate.
SEPT 21	Bitcoin surged 6.7% to $86,600, one of the largest single-day moves of the month.
SEPT 28	Nvidia announced an additional $150 billion in share repurchases, bringing its remaining authorization to $235 billion.
SEPT 30	The 10-year Treasury yield reached 5.29%, while the 30-year reached 5.64%. Both were major multi-year highs.

THE MACRO PICTURE

Macroeconomic & Geopolitical Overview

Macro

September's macroeconomic environment was characterized by an FOMC rate hike and a stock market that remained relatively resilient despite some of the year's most consequential economic developments. On September 16, the Federal Reserve unanimously raised the federal funds target range for the first time in over three years, increasing rates by 25 basis points to 3.75%–4.00%. Investors widely anticipated the hike leading into the September 15–16 FOMC meeting, largely because inflation remained above the Fed's target of 2%. August's PCE, the Fed's preferred inflation measure, was up 3.4% year-over-year. Much of the inflationary pressure was tied to elevated energy prices, as the U.S.-Iran conflict continued to disrupt oil markets. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, reached a September high of $110.19 on the day before the FOMC meeting. Over the course of the month, it rose 14.4%, ultimately closing at $103.53 per barrel.

The rate hike had its most immediate impact on the bond market, exemplified by the 10-year Treasury yield rising 11.13% during the month. The 10-year Treasury yield hit a high of 5.31% on the last day of the month, its highest level since 2002. While the 30-year bond yield is less susceptible to day-to-day news fluctuations, it still increased 7.43% over the course of the month, closing September at 5.64%.



THE AMERICAN FLAG ON DISPLAY AT THE UNITED STATES CAPITOL, WASHINGTON, D.C. PHOTO: GEORGE W. BRADBURY

Despite the bond shocks, equity markets showed mixed signals. The S&P 500 declined by only 0.45%, while the Nasdaq gained 1.86%. The Dow Jones Industrial Average and Russell 2000 experienced sharper losses, falling 4.29% and 5.40%, respectively. According to a Hartford Funds study, the S&P 500 has generated an average annual return of approximately 12.6% during periods when the 10-year Treasury yield was above 5%, compared with 9.1% when yields were above 4.5%. While this study does not represent a guarantee of future market performance, it does show that Treasury yields alone have not historically prevented equities from generating strong returns.

The commodities market more clearly reflected the shift toward the higher-rate market environment. Gold dropped 6.58%, while silver declined 9.25%. Rising Treasury yields reduced the incentive to hold precious metals, as higher interest payments from government debt increase the opportunity cost of holding non-yielding assets such as gold and silver. Rising Treasury yields also contributed to a stronger US Dollar. The US Dollar index rose 2.04% during September, further increasing the cost of American commodities for foreign buyers. Bitcoin continued its strong August performance into September, rising 6.37% during the month. Its resilience highlighted an additional market response to tighter financial conditions, as investors continued to treat digital assets differently from traditional non-yielding assets such as gold and silver. The divergence in performance reflected mixed signals for the higher-rate environment heading into October.

As the market enters the fourth quarter, October will provide several important tests for investors. The Federal Reserve's September projections placed the median year-end federal funds rate at 4.1%, indicating that policymakers still see the possibility of additional tightening. However, September's employment report, released on October 2, complicated the immediate outlook. Nonfarm payrolls rose by just 29,000 in September, well below the projected 84,000, contributing to a rise in unemployment to

4.2%. Revisions to previous months showed 60,000 fewer jobs than initially reported, including nearly 30,000 fewer jobs in August alone. On top of rising unemployment, wage growth slowed to 3%, its lowest rate since 2021.

Although the FOMC projected another hike later this year, weaker labor-market data give the Fed another reason to be cautious following September's rate hike. The Fed does not meet again until October 27–28 and, along with the bond market, will be heavily influenced by September's inflation data and additional economic indicators. New York Fed President John Williams said there was "no need for urgency" following September's hike, underscoring how much the outlook now depends on incoming data.

Rates & Currencies

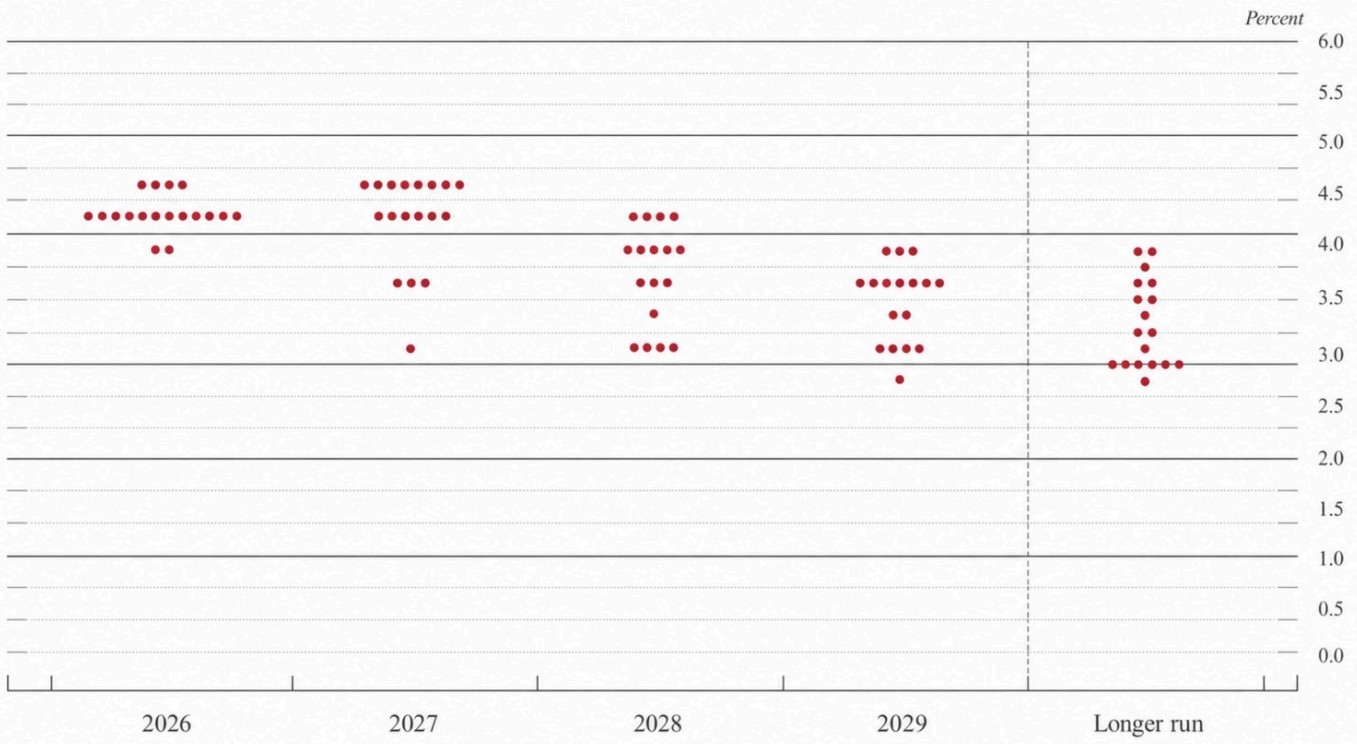
AS OF SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

TREASURY YIELDS	
2-Year	4.91%
10-Year	5.29%
30-Year	5.64%

DOLLAR & FX	
DXY	101.45
USD / EUR	0.8891
USD / JPY	157.078
USD / CNY	6.7035

FIGURE 2

FOMC participants' assessments of appropriate monetary policy: Midpoint of target range or target level for the federal funds rate



THE FOMC'S SEPTEMBER DOT PLOT OF PROJECTED FEDERAL FUNDS RATES THROUGH THE LONGER RUN. SOURCE: FEDERAL RESERVE SUMMARY OF ECONOMIC PROJECTIONS, SEPTEMBER 2026

Geo

U.S.–CHINA RELATIONS

On September 24, President Donald Trump met with Chinese President Xi Jinping in the Oval Office to discuss trade, artificial intelligence, and the broader U.S.-China relationship. It was Xi's first state visit to Washington since 2015. The two presidents agreed to extend the trade truce, originally set to expire on November 10, 2026, to January 10, 2027. The truce began after Trump and Xi met in Busan, South Korea, on October 30, 2025, to temporarily pause the U.S.-China trade war. Following that meeting, Washington reduced tariffs on Chinese imports, while Beijing resumed purchases of U.S. agricultural products and restored some exports of rare earths and other critical minerals.

During Xi's three-day visit to Washington, both presidents signaled a willingness to become more cooperative. Trump referenced the Flying Tigers, American pilots who fought alongside China against Japanese forces during World War II. Later at dinner, Xi referenced the history of U.S.-China cooperation, saying that the two countries had once "stood shoulder to shoulder" against Japanese aggression. He also argued that competition between the two countries should be a "race of catching up

with one another, not a wrestle in which one either wins or loses." However, the two did not fully align on artificial intelligence. Trump has promoted the term "super intelligence," or SI, and wants to prioritize continued AI development rather than impose broad restrictions, while Xi emphasized that AI should remain under human control and serve the well-being of the people. Although both leaders expressed interest in continued dialogue, they did not reach an agreement on how to manage AI risks.

Despite the positive tone, critics argued that the meeting produced few major breakthroughs. Daniel Kritenbrink, a former U.S. Assistant Secretary of State and current partner at The Asia Group, described the summit as being more about "optics" and "symbolism" than substantive outcomes. The two-month extension of the trade truce was also viewed as relatively short, leaving major disagreements over trade, technology, rare earths, and Taiwan, unresolved. Xi also announced that China would send two pandas to Zoo Atlanta, but the announcement did little to change the broader assessment that the summit produced few concrete geopolitical commitments.

On the economic side, however, the meeting did produce several developments. The U.S. and China operationalized their Boards of Trade and Investment, creating new channels for discussions on trade and investment. Under the Board of Trade, each country recommended more favorable tariff treatment for approximately $30 billion worth of non-sensitive goods. This includes U.S. agricultural products, fish and seafood, wood products, cosmetics, and medical devices, as well as Chinese consumer products such as toys and small appliances. However, these recommendations had not yet resulted in immediate tariff reductions, meaning that any economic benefits would depend on their implementation. The proposed $60 billion in combined tariff treatment was also relatively small compared with the approximately $415 billion in trade between the two countries last year, highlighting the limited scale of the potential changes.

The two countries also continued discussions surrounding AI safety, but their differing approaches remain a significant obstacle to cooperation. While both governments have reasons to avoid the risks associated with increasingly advanced AI systems, they disagree on how much oversight and regulation are necessary. Rather than establishing a formal agreement on managing these risks, the leaders left the issue for future discussions. The presidents are also expected to meet two more times in 2026, first at the APEC summit in Shenzhen in November and later at the G20 summit in Miami in December. These meetings could provide further opportunities to address unresolved economic and technological issues.

There are also questions about whether China is keeping up with the original truce. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent stated that China was meeting its commitment to purchase 25 million tons of U.S.

soybeans but was behind on its commitment to purchase $17 billion in other U.S. agricultural products. U.S. officials have also continued to raise concerns about Chinese rare-earth shipments remaining below desired levels. These issues demonstrate that even though both countries have taken steps toward cooperation, implementing their existing commitments remains a challenge.

Overall, the Trump-Xi meeting created a more cooperative tone between the two countries, but it did not resolve their major economic and geopolitical disagreements. The extension of the trade truce gives both countries additional time to negotiate, while the proposed tariff recommendations could provide economic benefits if they are implemented. However, disagreements over AI oversight, incomplete trade commitments, and unresolved tensions over Taiwan and rare earths show that significant obstacles remain. Looking forward, the next few months may be important in determining whether the U.S. and China can move beyond a temporary truce and toward a more sustainable economic relationship.

SPECIAL SECTION

Midterms

Though the months leading up to the midterms often carry high investor uncertainty, historical trends indicate stronger market performance following the election period. A Lincoln Financial analysis found that volatility historically increases approaching Election Day, as investors weigh potential changes in government policy and political control. Volatility for the S&P 500 averages a median of 24.5% during midterm election years, compared to 15.7% in non-midterm years. The volatility typically calms after Election day as uncertainty declines with no upcoming vote concerning investors.

The S&P 500 has historically rallied following midterm years. Lincoln Financial's analysis identified positive returns over the 12 months following every midterm election from 1950 to 2022. Over these periods, the average 12-month price return was 16.6%, peaking at 33.6% in 1964 and narrowing to 3.0% in 2014. Additional studies reflect similar historical patterns. Truist Chief Strategist, Keith Lerner, found that the average S&P 500 gain has been approximately 14.4%. Since 1950, the S&P 500 has risen 84% of all fourth quarters during midterm years. These post-midterm trends are highlighted by Fidelity's research as well. Scaling back to 1938, Fidelity found that the S&P 500 produced positive returns in the 12 months following midterm elections 95% of the time. Fidelity also reported an average 5% market return during the second year of a presidential term, compared to the 14% following the midterm election.

One of the most anticipated aspects of the midterm elections is the outcome itself, especially the possibility of Congress switching party control. Contrary to investor sentiment, the results historically have had a limited effect on the long-term market performance. In its analysis of historical market performance during midterm election cycles, Lincoln Financial also examined how S&P 500 returns varied across different government-control scenarios. The S&P has averaged a 14.5% return under a unified government, 11.7% when Congress is controlled by a different party than the president, and 13.8% when Congress is split between parties. While these returns differ slightly, all three outcomes have produced double-digit average gains, demonstrating the result that no one election result has consistently led to stronger market performance.

Looking ahead, the 2026 midterm elections will take place on Tuesday, November 3, with all 435 House seats and roughly one-third of the Senate seats up for election. As the Election Day approaches, markets may grow more volatile, but the historical analyses reflect that the uncertainty matters more than the result of the election itself. Past midterm cycles have shown rising volatility going into the election and strong S&P 500 returns in the following year. With the 2026 market uncertainty surrounding rate-hikes, interest rates, earnings, inflation, and geopolitical tensions, the midterm elections won't be the only topic driving market volatility.

UNDER THE HOOD

Company Deep Dive

Shopify (SHOP)		SEPTEMBER CLOSE $148.30 +0.6% MTD
SUBSCRIPTION REV (Q2 '26) $802M	SHOPIFY CATALOG 1B+ products	P/E (TTM) >100

After closing August up over 25%, Shopify (SHOP) inched 0.6% higher in September. Despite a flat close to the month, Shopify's stock experienced significant volatility throughout September. During the first half of September, SHOP was down over 15%. However, on September 21, Shopify and Meta announced a

partnership enabling Muse, Meta's personal AI agent, to browse and complete purchases on Shopify's marketplace. Following the announcement, the stock recovered, climbing back to above $140 (right around September's opening price of $143.66). Meta CEO, Mark Zuckerberg provided his comments on the new partnership by explaining that with Muse, consumers will purchase more products while allowing merchants to increase sales.

Shopify's business model consists of two revenue-generating components: subscription and merchant solutions (success). At the end of June, subscriptions revenue accounted for 23% of its total revenue while merchant solutions accounted for 77%. Shopify charges merchants on a recurring basis (either monthly or yearly). With the subscription, merchants have the ability to publicly host their storefront on Shopify, as well as utilize tools like Sidekick to grow their customer base. The company also offers tiered subscriptions, with higher tier plans offering additional features and more advanced customization options. Shopify generates a majority of its revenue based on the success of the merchants on its platform. Shopify charges a payment processing fee of between 2.25% + 30¢ and 2.9% + 30¢ for every transaction made on the platform; the lower fee is associated with the highest tiered subscription (Plus), while the highest fee is representative of the lowest tier (Basic). SHOP also generates revenue through currency conversion fees, the sale of shipping labels, and point of sale (POS) hardware. The company reported that merchant solutions revenue is directly correlated to the volume of gross merchandise value (GMV) processed through its platform, so the more products merchants sell, the more revenue Shopify generates.

Shopify's integration with both agentic and non-agentic artificial intelligence models has been vital to its GMV and revenue growth. On August 5, during its Q2 2026 conference call, President Harley Finkelstein explained that Shopify's second quarter was the fifth straight quarter of GMV growth above 30%. Alongside Shopify's rising GMV, at the beginning of August, the company's compound annual growth rate (CAGR) since Q2 of 2021 was 18%.

On that same conference call, Finkelstein offered information on the newest projects driving Shopify's growth today; the majority of these projects relate to artificial intelligence, more specifically, agentic models. In order to maximize the browsing experience for shoppers, Shopify has introduced an extremely organized catalog which allows for independent AI agents to smoothly filter through product categories (large and small) to provide shoppers with a list of products that best fit the search. Finkelstein described the catalog as "…the discovery engine for the future." He went on to explain how AI searches powered by the Shopify catalog convert twice as many shoppers compared to searches using

scraped data. Shopify's built-in ecommerce AI agent, Sidekick, provides merchants with early guidance to establish traction and sales. The on-site chatbot also provides analytics and strategic consulting once a merchant is well-established on the platform. Sidekick's guidance during onboarding led to an 8% increase in merchants reaching 5 orders within the first 15 days of opening.

Shopify has secured partnerships with OpenAI, Meta, Google, and Microsoft, and is capitalizing on the continued growth of artificial intelligence. As its catalog gets more detailed, and tools such as Sidekick develop more capabilities for merchants, Shopify is positioned to follow its recent trend of recurring revenue and total gross merchandise value growth. One major headwind Shopify could encounter relates to its trailing-twelve-months (TTM) price-to-earnings ratio, which currently sits above 100. A ratio this high leaves a small margin for slowed growth or disappointing earnings due to extremely high investor expectations.

STARTUP WATCH

Founders Spotlight

Merchant

Merchant Live

This edition highlights Merchant Live, an app designed to make experiencing live events easier by helping people plan, buy, and go together. Merchant Live brings event discovery, ticket comparison and tracking, and social planning all into one place, so attending your favorite events becomes an even greater possibility.

What Merchant Live Does

Billions of dollars are overspent annually on online ticket platforms for live events. Many seats are resold across 6 or more marketplaces, forcing fans to manually compare prices for half an hour or overspend without knowing about a cheaper option. Merchant Live is an app that books any live event in one place while also making it easier for users to attend events with friends. Users tell it what event they are looking for, and Merchant finds the event, shows every seller's price, side-by-side, and helps users decide when to buy. Users can plan with friends and see who's going, where they are sitting, and find the most popular concerts among their network.

Launch and Growth

The majority of Merchant Live's asset creation and artwork design comes from Texas Christian University (TCU). However, all of its growth and marketing has stemmed from Ohio State, as Chief Growth Officer (CGO) and Ohio State student Charlie Scullion is leading a major advertising campaign. Through flyers, tabling, influencer posts, and Greek life sponsorships, Merchant Live has begun to see some early traction. After recently launching the app on iOS, the team was able to impress upon 16,400 different accounts, while accumulating over 61,000 views and 2,100 followers across all videos and media. This growth took place over a four-day period.

Expansion Plans

Taking a step back and evaluating the successes and pitfalls of the Ohio State Campaign, the team developed a framework to expand to different University campuses and cities all over the U.S. The group has ambitions of becoming well established in 20 different schools with a monthly user rate of 5,000 in the next 2 1/2 months. Schools scheduled for expansion projects over the next two weeks include: Vanderbilt, CU Boulder, TCU, UT (University of Texas).

Company Background

Merchant Live has been in development for over two years. With the help of a $25,000 funding Grant received from the Vanderbilt Chancellor's competition, the team was able to develop a viable product and working iOS app that was ready for launch at the first target school: Ohio State.

Software

Merchant Live runs as a website and native iOS app. It utilizes backend data scraping and machine learning algorithms to collect about 49 million price observations since August of 2026, each one being a single seller's price for an event at a moment in time. The startup has developed a large historical record of how ticket prices move, ultimately using it to predict ticket price changes and alert users of ideal buying opportunities. The catalog holds over 620,000 unique events, over 95,000 performers and about 60,000 venues across 8,000+ cities. All ticket data is aggregated together and hyperlinked based on the cheapest price across all platforms, including fees.

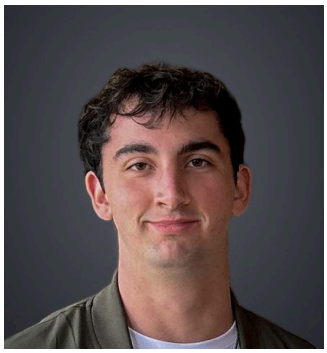
Meet the Founders



Nosa Agbonghae

CO-FOUNDER · CEO

Vanderbilt University



Ryan Touchton

CO-FOUNDER · CTO

Vanderbilt University



Charlie Scullion

CGO

Ohio State University



Hayden Ward

CMO

Texas Christian University

CLOSE TO HOME

OSU Student Impact

On September 9, Ohio State announced that Google will be building an on-campus AI facility in Ohio State's Innovation District on West Campus to expand campuswide AI technology access. On September 17, in President Ravi V. Bellamkonda's first State of the University address, he spoke about how this will strengthen the second year of the AI Fluency initiative. The initiative aims for every student, beginning with the class of 2029, to graduate "AI fluent." That means understanding how AI works, knowing its benefits and limitations in their field, and being able to use it effectively in their major. Then, on September 29, Ohio State and Google Cloud formally announced the partnership. Bellamkonda described the partnership as it "unites two powerhouses of innovation to create excellence at scale for our students, faculty and staff and the state we serve." The partnership marks one of the largest partnerships between Google Public Sector and any U.S. university.

This initiative will transform students' educational experience at Ohio State. Ohio State is building a 24/7 virtual assistant for advising questions and career planning. The virtual assistant could reduce wait times for quick questions that usually require an appointment. Additionally, select faculty and students will gain access to technology at no additional cost such as Google Workspace for Education and Gemini Enterprise, software that companies are paying big money for. Google is also releasing a research ambassador program that recruits Ohio State students to work alongside Google teams, gaining valuable

first-hand experience in the industry. A major component of the partnership is using AI to accelerate scientific discovery. Ohio State researchers will soon have access to more than 200 AI models from Google and Google DeepMind, including AlphaFold, Google Earth Engine and agentic AI like AlphaEvolve. These tools could change how scientists approach drug discovery, turn satellite images into useful data on the environment, and solve complex math problems more efficiently, and that's only a few of the possibilities. The work will be done in Ohio State's AI Hub, which brings together researchers from 15 colleges across the university. Athletics is one of Ohio State's biggest investments, and recovery has become a major emphasis over the past few years. Athletes and trainers pay such close attention to sleep patterns, body battery, and how long it takes to recover between practices and games. This partnership also includes Project SCARLET, an AI platform that uses predictive models and advanced analytics to optimize Buckeye athletes' training and recovery across all 36 sports.

Regardless of their intended career path, the expectation in any job is that new hires know how to effectively use AI in the workplace. Ohio State is providing students with unique opportunities to gain those skills through its courses, which will give students a real advantage when it comes to recruiting. At the end of the day, having access to all this AI technology is great, but what really matters is knowing how to use it.

THE BACK PAGE

Closing

Fisher Fun Fact

The Fisher College of Business is ranked among the top business schools in the nation by US News & World Report, yet some Ohio State students may not know how Fisher got its name. Behind the name is Max M. Fisher, an Ohio State alumnus, businessman, philanthropist, and one of the most influential donors in university history.

Max M. Fisher came to Ohio State in 1926 on a football scholarship. He graduated 4 years later and moved to Detroit, Michigan, to join his father's oil reclamation business. Using hard work, instinct and incredible business communication skills learned at Ohio State, he grew the business into one of the largest gas station chains in the Midwest, before he sold it to The Ohio Oil Company (since renamed Marathon) in 1959 for $40 million.

More than 60 years after his graduation, Max M. Fisher made his historic investment in his alma mater. In 1993, Fisher donated $20 million to The Ohio State University's business college. In recognition of the gift, Ohio State officially renamed the school the Max M. Fisher College of Business. His contribution directly began the construction of the modern Fisher College of Business, replacing the college's former home in Hagerty Hall.



THE MAX M. FISHER COLLEGE OF BUSINESS GATE ON THE OHIO STATE CAMPUS. PHOTO: GEORGE W. BRADBURY

Fisher's impact went far beyond the buildings. He once said, "Buildings are just the enabling devices. It's not just the walls, but what goes on inside that brings out the best in our students and empowers them to impact their communities." Max M. Fisher's donation has benefited thousands of students who walk the grounds of the business school every day, leaving a lasting legacy that continues to shape Fisher today.

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Macroeconomic Overview · Midterms · Fisher Fun Fact



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Market Overview

ALL PHOTOGRAPHS BY GEORGE W. BRADBURY, VP OF FINANCE & STRATEGY.

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